

Dead Air

Voice Line Writing Checklist

Hidden rule: Dispatcher always tells the truth. GPS, CB, signs, dashboard anomalies, and the road itself manipulate the player.

Core Writing Rules

- [] Every Dispatcher line must be factually true.
- [] Dispatcher can be uncertain. 'I don't know' is allowed. Truthful does not mean omniscient.
- [] Following Dispatcher's actual route instructions should always help the player stay on the real route or survive.
- [] GPS should begin trustworthy, then increasingly lie.
- [] The hostile CB should mix believable truths, half-truths, and fabricated claims to discredit Dispatcher.
- [] Environmental systems can lie: signs, mileage, fuel, clock, repeated landmarks, traffic, and route presentation.
- [] Do not prove Dispatcher is trustworthy too early. The player should discover the pattern.
- [] Silence matters. Not every horror beat needs dialogue.

ACT 1 - A Completely Normal Job

Goal: Establish a believable routine delivery and teach the player that Dispatcher and GPS normally agree.

LINE 01 - Dispatcher - DA_001

- [] Identify the truck/player with a believable callsign or truck number.
- [] State the real destination.
- [] State the real initial route.
- [] Frame the job as routine and low-risk.
- [] Sound calm, normal, and professional.
- [] Include no horror hint.

Player takeaway: I know where I am going and Dispatcher sounds reliable.

LINE 02 - GPS - DA_002

- ☐ Confirm the same route Dispatcher gave.
- ☐ Establish the GPS voice/style.
- ☐ Be intentionally mundane.
- ☐ Tell the truth here so the player learns to trust GPS before it begins lying.

Player takeaway: Dispatcher and GPS agree.

LINE 03 - Normal CB / Radio - DA_003

- ☐ Establish ordinary radio traffic before the hostile CB appears.
- ☐ Use something mundane: road chatter, weather, another driver, or generic trucking talk.
- ☐ Make the highway feel inhabited.
- ☐ Do not make this voice overtly creepy.

Player takeaway: There are other normal people out here.

ACT 2 - The First Contradiction

Goal: Make the player think the GPS has a technical problem, not that reality is supernatural.

LINE 04 - GPS - DA_004

- ☐ Give the first false route instruction.
- ☐ Contradict the route established by Dispatcher.
- ☐ Keep the delivery mechanical and confident.
- ☐ Make the lie plausible enough to resemble a normal reroute.

Player takeaway: Maybe the GPS updated the route?

LINE 05 - Dispatcher - DA_004

- ☐ Correct the GPS.
- ☐ Give the actual safe/correct route.
- ☐ Offer a believable, truthful explanation for why the GPS information may be bad if Dispatcher knows one.
- ☐ If Dispatcher does not know why, say so rather than inventing an explanation.
- ☐ Remain calm.

Player takeaway: GPS can be wrong. Dispatcher still seems reasonable.

CHOICE 1 - Low Stakes

- ☐ Player physically chooses between two roads.
- ☐ Following Dispatcher must be the objectively correct/safe route.
- ☐ Do not make the correct choice immediately obvious.

LINE 06 - Dispatcher - DA_005

- ☐ React accurately to the player's Choice 1 route.
- ☐ If the player obeyed, acknowledge it calmly.
- ☐ If the player ignored Dispatch, truthfully say they are off the intended route.
- ☐ If recovery is possible, tell them exactly how to recover.
- ☐ Do not become threatening.

Player takeaway: Dispatcher is tracking what I actually did.

ACT 3 - Someone Else Is Listening

LINE 07 - Hostile CB - DA_006

- ☐ Address the player directly.
- ☐ Know something the player does not expect a stranger to know.
- ☐ Use one believable truth to earn attention.
- ☐ Begin implying that Dispatcher cannot be trusted.
- ☐ Keep it short.
- ☐ Do not explain who the speaker is.

Player takeaway: How does this person know that?

LINE 08 - Dispatcher - shortly after DA_006

- ☐ Truthfully identify the transmission as unauthorized/interference if that is what Dispatcher can know.
- ☐ Tell the player to ignore it.
- ☐ Do not claim knowledge Dispatcher does not have.
- ☐ Sound practical rather than defensive.

Player takeaway: Dispatcher says the strange voice is interference - which is exactly what a liar might say.

SILENT ENVIRONMENTAL BEATS

[] DA_007 - Mileage sign gives false/inconsistent information.

[] DA_008 - Distinctive car appears.

[] DA_009 - The same car appears again impossibly.

[] DA_010 - Fuel display lies, then recovers.

[] DA_011 - Fog begins.

Important: Do not immediately comment on these beats. Let the player notice the world lying on its own.

ACT 4 - Choice 2: Everyone Starts Ganging Up on Dispatch

Goal: Make every available source point away from the one truthful source.

LINE 09 - GPS - Choice 2

[] Give the wrong route.

[] Sound absolutely confident.

[] Do not glitch so much that the player instantly dismisses it.

Player takeaway: The GPS still looks authoritative.

LINE 10 - Dispatcher - Choice 2

[] Give the correct route.

[] Contradict GPS.

[] Sound more urgent than before.

[] Give only explanations Dispatcher can truthfully support.

[] If the situation no longer makes sense to Dispatcher, admit it.

Player takeaway: Dispatcher is still consistent, but now he sounds worried.

LINE 11 - Hostile CB - Choice 2

[] Tell the player Dispatcher is lying.

[] Provide convincing fabricated evidence or a manipulative half-truth.

[] Reference something from earlier to make the accusation feel earned.

- [] Encourage the player toward the wrong route.
- [] Make the lie emotionally persuasive, not cartoonishly evil.

Player takeaway: Maybe Dispatch really is leading me somewhere.

ACT 5 - The Argument Becomes Personal

LINE 12 - Dispatcher - DA_012

- [] Acknowledge that the interference is not normal.
- [] Tell the player the truthful route/data Dispatcher can actually verify.
- [] Tell the player to remain on the assigned road.
- [] Do not pretend to understand the supernatural events.
- [] Allow fear or uncertainty without making Dispatcher dishonest.

Player takeaway: Dispatcher does not understand everything, but his route information remains consistent.

LINE 13 - Hostile CB - DA_012

- [] Directly undermine Dispatcher.
- [] Invent a believable story about missing drivers, previous incidents, or Dispatcher's motives.
- [] Use details that sound specific enough to be credible.
- [] Do not reveal the true nature of the entity.
- [] Push the player toward distrusting the only accurate source.

Player takeaway: The CB's story sounds frighteningly plausible.

DA_013 - Clock Anomaly

- [] The displayed time becomes impossible.
- [] Use no explanatory dialogue.
- [] Return the clock to something plausible afterward.

ACT 6 - The World Abandons You

DA_014 - Silence

- [] Drop normal CB/radio ambience.
- [] Reduce traffic/world presence if practical.

- ☐ Leave engine, tires, cab movement, and other intimate truck sounds.
- ☐ Hold the silence long enough to make the next line hit.

LINE 14 - GPS

- ☐ Give objectively impossible or nonsensical navigation information.
- ☐ Recalculate when the player has not changed course, or present impossible distance/destination information.
- ☐ Make it clear GPS is no longer merely outdated.

Player takeaway: The navigation system itself is actively wrong.

LINE 15 - Hostile CB - DA_015

- ☐ Break the silence with a very short warning.
- ☐ Tell the player they are going the wrong way even if they followed Dispatcher correctly.
- ☐ Do not explain.
- ☐ Disappear immediately afterward.

Player takeaway: What if every choice I made was wrong?

ACT 7 - Something Is Following the Truck

DA_016 - Following Headlights

- ☐ Headlights appear behind the truck.
- ☐ Let the player observe them before anyone talks.
- ☐ Allow the distance/behavior to feel physically wrong.

LINE 16 - Dispatcher

- ☐ Truthfully state what Dispatcher can verify about traffic/vehicles on that road.
- ☐ If there should be nobody there, say so.
- ☐ Tell the player not to stop if that is the safest truthful instruction.
- ☐ Tell them to stay on the real route.
- ☐ Let Dispatcher sound genuinely scared or concerned.

Player takeaway: Even Dispatcher does not know what is behind me.

ACT 8 - Exit 17

Goal: Everything except Dispatcher converges on the same lie: TAKE EXIT 17.

LINE 17 - Hostile CB - DA_017

- [] Tell the player to take Exit 17.
- [] Claim Exit 17 is the only way out.
- [] Claim Dispatcher is trying to keep the player trapped.
- [] Make this urgent and emotionally persuasive.
- [] Suggest there may not be another chance.

LINE 18 - GPS - DA_017

- [] Give an unequivocal TAKE EXIT 17 instruction.
- [] Keep it short, mechanical, and confident.

Player takeaway: GPS and CB agree.

Environmental Lie - Exit 17 Sign

- [] Road signage should also point the destination toward Exit 17.
- [] Optionally reinforce the lie with dashboard/fuel information.
- [] Make the physical world appear to validate the wrong choice.

LINE 19 - Dispatcher - DA_017

- [] Explicitly tell the player NOT to take Exit 17.
- [] Tell the player to remain on the main highway.
- [] Be completely correct.
- [] Make this Dispatcher's most urgent/emotional line.
- [] Do not introduce false lore just to sound dramatic.

Player takeaway: Everything says EXIT 17. Only Dispatcher says stay straight.

LINE 20 - Hostile CB - Final Counterargument

- [] Give one final reason to distrust Dispatcher.
- [] Use earlier established material rather than introducing random new lore.
- [] Optionally claim Dispatcher is not real, is responsible, or has done this before - but make the claim a lie.
- [] Cut out after the line.

[] After this, no source should help the player decide.

FINAL CHOICE

[] Stay on the main highway = correct route.

[] Take Exit 17 = manipulated/wrong route.

[] Make the player physically commit with the truck.

[] Do not label either option as right or wrong.

ACT 9 - Consequences

LINE 21 - Dispatcher - DA_018

[] React truthfully to the player's final route.

[] If the player stayed straight, confirm they are still on the correct route without over-explaining.

[] If the player took Exit 17, react differently and accurately to the danger/deviation.

[] Do not immediately explain the mystery.

Player takeaway: My final choice mattered.

LINE 22 - Final Sting - Radio / CB / Dispatch

[] Keep this extremely short.

[] Do NOT explain the whole plot.

[] Reveal or imply one unsettling fact that makes the player reconsider the run.

[] Possible purpose: imply the truck disappeared, this happened before, the delivery was manipulated, or someone is still searching.

[] Choose one mystery, not several.

[] Then cut to black / ending.

Ending Logic

Best / Escape Ending

[] Player rejects GPS, CB, false signs, and false dashboard data.

[] Player remains on the main highway.

[] Dispatcher's instructions prove to have been consistently accurate.

[] The ending may reveal this subtly rather than saying 'Dispatcher was right.'

Exit 17 Ending

- ☐ Player follows the coordinated lie onto Exit 17.
- ☐ Road/reality can become impossible.
- ☐ Radio contact can fail.
- ☐ End in disappearance, entrapment, void, or another bad outcome.

Lost Ending

- ☐ Player repeatedly follows false GPS/CB routes.
- ☐ The world loops, repeats, or traps them.
- ☐ Repetition should connect back to earlier landmarks/roads.

Void Loss

- ☐ If the entire tractor/trailer rig leaves the valid road corridor long enough, trigger SUCKED INTO THE VOID.
- ☐ This is a gameplay fail state, separate from the narrative route endings.

Final Consistency Test for Every Dispatcher Line

Before approving any Dispatcher line, ask:

- ☐ Is this factually true in the game world?
- ☐ If Dispatcher gives a route instruction, does following it help the player survive or stay on the real route?
- ☐ Is Dispatcher claiming knowledge he could not actually have?
- ☐ If he does not know something, would an honest 'I don't know' be stronger?
- ☐ Does the line preserve the possibility that the player might still distrust him?

Hidden pattern for replay: DISPATCH NEVER LIED.